

family plays ball, hikes, or works in the garden. At night Frank and Emily help with the boys' homework rather than tell them to go to their room and do it on their own.

Frank does odd jobs around the county and Emily sees one or two patients in her home. Their lives have none of the hurry and stress that wore them down in Providence. They've recovered their sense of family. Frank and Emily believe they did the right thing—for themselves as well as the kids.

To help decide how to make the tradeoff between retiring and stashing money away for your kids, you may want to ask your kids themselves. After a barbecue one day Vicki and I were drinking coffee with our hosts and their 11-year-old daughter. Dad is a high-powered executive with an airline. Mom stays at home and raises three children. We were talking about retirement when their 11-year-old put down her book and started to listen. She's bright, vivacious, studious, and quick on the uptake. We had been beating up on her father a little, and Vicki wanted to turn the tide. She asked the daughter to name the three things she liked most about her dad.

She thought a bit, then said, "He's a great sport. He's always ready to play catch with me, or go sailing or swimming."

"Anything else?"

"He helps me with my homework. And third, he's always there when I need him. He'll come get me at a party, for example, if I'm uncomfortable and want to come home early."

I thought her answers were tender and poignant, but to my surprise her father got upset. "You little jerk," he said. "You didn't even mention how hard I work to be able to afford a big house, a room of your own, piano lessons, new clothes. Not to mention your college education."

She recovered quickly. "That's important too, Dad."